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Section Title(S): The Joking Relationship

A !Kung told us that joking was not only amusing, it was useful in that it taught people, young men especially, not to lose their tempers, but to have poise, instead, in their social relations. I thought that joking served many good purposes, and that the laughter provided for all an outlet for feelings of hostility and a certain amount of release from tension imposed by social restraints.

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Though the !Kung enjoy the joking relationship, I had the impression that their primary concern lay with the prohibition against joking. They say that they *_koa* the person with whom they may not joke and *_koa* the joking. The verb *_koa* means to respect (as a !Kung respects his mother-in-law), to avoid (as one avoids joking with a mother-in-law or avoids saying aloud the name of the gods), and it also means to fear (as one fears a lion). It would be madness, the !Kung say, for one to joke with someone with whom he did not have the joking relationship.

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When I was beginning to learn about the joking relationship, some of my questions sounded to the !Kung like obscenities, and to have them come from the mouth of a sedate, middle-aged woman threw people into paroxysms of laughter. I remember the howls that arose when I asked if one could joke with a daughter. ≠Toma, when he could get his breath, said he knew I was only beginning to learn the !Kung ways, and he wanted me to know he did not blame me when I said such bad things.

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The pattern of the joking relationship emerges basically as follows. In the nuclear family, ego avoids joking with his parents and his offspring. Among siblings, according to a cross and parallel pattern in which a sex differentiation is made, a male jokes with his brother, but not with his sister; a female jokes with her sister, but not with her brother. Among other lineal kin and collaterals, the pattern is one of alternating generations; no sex differentiation is made. Ego avoids joking with his uncles, aunts, nephews, and nieces, who are, respectively, of his parents' and his offspring's generations. He jokes with his cousins, who are of his generation. He jokes with his grandparents and his grandchildren, who are in generations alternate to the generation of his parents and offspring.

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Affines fall into a similar pattern. Ego's spouse's parents are like his parents; ego avoids joking with them. His offspring's spouse's parents are like himself; he jokes with them. His offspring's spouses are like  207 his offspring; he avoids joking. Among siblings of spouse, as among siblings, a sex differentiation is made and a cross-parallel pattern obtains. Ego takes the same position as that of his spouse.⁴ A man jokes with his wife's sister and avoids joking with her brother, as his wife does. A woman jokes with her husband's brother and avoids joking with his sister, as her husband does.

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4. I formerly used the expression here that "the point of reference is the spouse." The interpretation that "ego takes the same position as h spouse" with respect to **joking** with siblings appeals to me and I believe throws more light on the cross and parallel pattern. The interpretation comes from Johannes Fabian, from his paper "!"Kung Bushman Kinship: Componential Analysis and Alternative Interpretations," *Anthropos*, 60 (1965), 694, 697. He makes his interpretation as follows: "Spouses occupy the same position in the kinship system." I do not find that an appropriate statement for the whole system, including the homonymous method of applying terms and the name-relationship, but it fits the position of both spouses with respect to the parents, siblings, offspring, and primary affines of each. They parallel each other in the **joking** relationship. (See Fig. 3 as well as Fig 1.)

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